

Why should I buy the HTC Hero?

1. It's got the heart of Linux! Yes, Android being open source, there will never be a dearth of third-party applications to power the phone.
2. The Sense UI and the touch-screen QWERTY keyboard are the best in the business.
3. The hardware design is very risqué and succeeds in catching a lot of attention (a la 'the chin').
4. Android's default browser (it's not Chrome, at least not yet) is based on Webkit, is dizzying fast and renders Web pages in a very customised and easy-to-use layout.
5. Tight integration with Google accounts makes sure you carry your information everywhere you go, be it the calendar entries, contacts, tasks list or even the RSS feeds.

Should I give HTC Hero a pass?

1. Although it has a 5 mega-pixel camera, the shutter is extremely slow and highly sensitive. Moreover, the absence of a flash renders the powerful camera absolutely useless.
2. While the operating system is open source and most of the applications are developed by freelance developers, this phone can hardly justify its price tag.
3. The display gets washed out under direct sunlight.
4. It has no radio and no proximity sensor to switch off the display once the phone is near the ear.
5. The GPS takes a long time to get a satellite lock.

Whether HTC plans to support other social networks too, isn't clear as yet.

Text input

HTC Hero has an on-screen keyboard with different layouts—the traditional phone keypad, Compact QWERTY and QWERTY. It has a simulated haptic-forced feedback every time you hit a key. HTC has built its own touch keyboard from the ground up. The keyboard also has a text prediction algorithm that is almost 98 per cent accurate in daily use and 100 per cent accurate if you type only English words.

However, it is advisable to run through the training mode to help it learn your particular tapping quirks. It's probably the best touchscreen typing experience I've ever encountered. I never lags behind. I am a BlackBerry addict myself and yet, Hero did not make me miss BB's physical keyboard. The good news is: Hero supports the cut-copy-paste drill too.

On the whole, HTC Hero is a phone for both casual and business users. Since it gets synced to MS Exchange Server too, getting your e-mails will never be an issue. It is also one of the very few phones that support 'over the air' updates. The music player is also very competent, unless compared to the iPhone or Sony's Walkman Series phones. The touch UI is very snappy. However, what takes the cake is its strong integration with social networks, intuitive user interface and extremely rich Market Place that houses any app that one might ever need.

However, a price tag of Rs 32,000 (Rs 35,000 in Maharashtra) is a bit too steep for the Indian market. If it ever drops to the range of Rs 25,000-Rs 28,000, it should be the ideal phone to buy! 

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An avid Twitter user and a social media enthusiast, the author is a passionate blogger and a professional gamer too. He also feels compelled to be opinionated about anything that comes his way, be it Linux distributions, our marketing strategies, table etiquettes or even the fabled Ramsay movies!



▲ Teeter - A fun game that uses Hero's extra-sensitive accelerometers



▲ The Gmail App for Android



▲ GTalk for Android